



relentlessly aggressive 24-year-old Belarusian whacked an astounding 51 winners, an Open Era record, during the two-hour, 28-minute battle. After seizing her first Grand Slam crown on her fourth championship point, an ecstatic Sabalenka said, “[It] is the best day of my life right now. I’m super happy that I was able to handle all those emotions and win this one.”

BEST MEN’S CAREER COMEBACK

Alexander Zverev overcame a horrific ankle injury that tore three ligaments and left him writhing in pain during his 2022 French Open semifinal against Nadal. The mishap ended the former world No. 2’s season that year. Until the spring of 2023, Zverev, still in pain and unable

Chaos in Cincinnati: In a match where experience barely prevailed over youth. Djokovic, 36, had to stave off a match point to surmount Carlos Alcaraz, 20, in a thriller that lasted 3 hours, 49 minutes. GETTYIMAGES

to move the way he used to, won only three of his first nine matches and lost his first seven encounters with top-10 opponents. But he exorcised any demons at Roland Garros 2023 by making the semifinals for a third straight year — despite not being allowed to give himself a diabetes insulin injection on court and having to take a bathroom break for it. The 6’6” rocket server capped his impressive comeback when he qualified for the

Nitto ATP Finals, where he notched big wins over Alcaraz and Andrey Rublev to finish the year ranked No. 7.

BEST WOMEN’S CAREER COMEBACK

Neither giving birth to her first child in 2022 nor the anguish of her homeland’s war against Russia’s unprovoked invasion slowed the determined comeback of Elina Svitolina. Starting the season in April ranked 1,344, the 29-year-old Ukrainian won a 500 event in Strasbourg and, hitting harder than ever, made the Roland Garros quarterfinals and Wimbledon semifinals, pulling off a big 7-5, 6-7, 6-2 quarterfinal upset over No. 1 Iga Swiatek to finish No. 25. Hats (or